point to the park, for a sermon delivered by a leader of the sect. Other than the Kabirpanthis, pilgrims throng the fort on Janmashtami and Ramnavami too.

Wildlife activist Ajay Dubey, concerned over the potential ecological disturbance to wildlife, had petitioned the NGT in December 2024. On August 8, the tribunal asked the state forest department to work out an SOP for such pilgrimages. That's turning into a tragi-comedy of errors. A committee was set up, which duly capped the number of pilgrims at 5,000 but recommended travel by vehicles to the fort—environmentally a more dangerous idea. "A total of 5,000 pilgrims would mean as many as 800-900 vehicles! That would probably disturb wildlife more than the walking pilgrims," says Dubey.

BIO-DEGRADING

Satpura has a bigger concern. The Nagdwari mela, held on Naagpanchami every August, attracted 600,000 devouts this year. The pilgrims trek to the old site of Kaajri village (now relocated) and stay for a week. There exist no arrangements for stay or sanitation. Witnesses speak of plastics, faeces and food remains left behind in the rains. Similarly, on Shivratri, lakhs of pilgrims reach the designated biosphere reserve of Pachmarhi. Pilgrim footfalls are also increasing at Jhiri village, near the Ratapani tiger reserve.

Pench and Kanha, too, used to have pilgrimages inside the core area. In the early 2000s, the Pench management convinced devotees to shift their prayers outside. Kanha's annual mela was stopped in the 1990s after a tiger killed a devotee.

The Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, allows religious practices that predated the notification of national parks. The difference is that, back in the day, these visits were a trickle. Now, the climate has changed, so has demographics. And to reprise our old line, wildlife has no vote. ■

ODISHA

If the Goal is Too Far, Mend it Like Majhi

The grassroots CM takes the ball from Naveen Patnaik's famed sports policy and flicks it to the countryside. Rural Odisha will reap the bonanza

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

THE ODISHA BJP'S FIRST-TIME CHIEF MINISTER, Mohan Charan Majhi, has not had an easy ride—what with the colossus-like Naveen Patnaik around as a constant point of reference. Now Majhi is taking a leaf out of his predecessor's book to get some of that éclat. With years of work, Naveen had put Odisha on the international sporting map, earning renown as one of India's most sport-forward states. Capital Bhubaneswar was its node, hosting marquee hockey tournaments at its Kalinga Stadium. Majhi's innovation is to take that legacy and extend it beyond the capital city.

His government has launched a flagship programme to construct stadiums in all 314 blocks of the state, with an outlay of Rs 4,124 crore spread over five years. Alongside, a separate package of Rs 600 crore has been earmarked for the establishment of district-level and regional sports hubs. Together, the scale of the two initiatives bespeak a distinct point of evolution in Odisha's sports policy—world-class infrastructure will come closer home for thousands of young athletes across the state.

Sports and youth services minister Suryabanshi Suraj had presented the master plan back in February, with architectural designs and videos of the envisaged facili-



LOVE OF THE GAME A match in a rural pocket of Odisha's Khordha district

ARABINDA MAHAPATRA